

Virtue Ethics

Introduction to Philosophy

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Virtue Ethics

What Is Virtue Ethics?

- Developed by Aristotle in the **Nicomachean Ethics**
- Focuses on **character** rather than rules or consequences
- Central question: What kind of person should I be?
- A **virtue** is a stable disposition to feel and act well

Virtue ethics is one of the three major normative theories in ethics. Unlike deontology, which focuses on duties and rules, and consequentialism, which evaluates actions by their outcomes, virtue ethics centers on the character of the moral agent. Aristotle argued that ethics begins not with the question “What should I do?” but “What kind of person should I be?” A virtue, on his account, is not merely a habit of acting in certain ways but a stable disposition to feel, choose, and act appropriately across a range of situations.

The Virtues and the Mean

- Virtues are the **mean** between two vices (excess and deficiency)
- Example: courage lies between **cowardice** (deficiency) and **recklessness** (excess)
- The mean is relative to the person and circumstances
- **Phronesis** (practical wisdom) guides us to the right mean

Aristotle’s doctrine of the mean holds that each virtue is a middle ground between two corresponding vices — one of excess and one of deficiency. For example, generosity is the mean between miserliness and profligacy. Crucially, the mean is not a fixed mathematical midpoint but is relative to the individual and the situation. This is why practical wisdom (**phronesis**) is the architectonic virtue: it is the capacity to discern what the situation calls for and to respond accordingly. Without phronesis, the other virtues cannot be exercised well.

Eudaimonia: The Good Life

- The goal of a virtuous life is **eudaimonia** — human flourishing
- Not mere pleasure or wealth, but living and doing well as a human being
- Eudaimonia is an **activity** of the soul in accordance with virtue
- Requires a complete life — not achievable in a single moment

Eudaimonia, often translated as “happiness,” is better rendered as “flourishing” or “living well.” For Aristotle, eudaimonia is not a subjective feeling but an objective condition: it is the activity of the soul in accordance with virtue over a complete lifetime. This means that a person cannot flourish in isolation or in a single moment — flourishing requires the sustained exercise of virtues within a community. One classic objection is whether severe misfortune (poverty, illness, the death of loved ones) can undermine eudaimonia even in a virtuous person. Aristotle acknowledges that external goods matter, though he insists that virtue is the most important component of the good life.

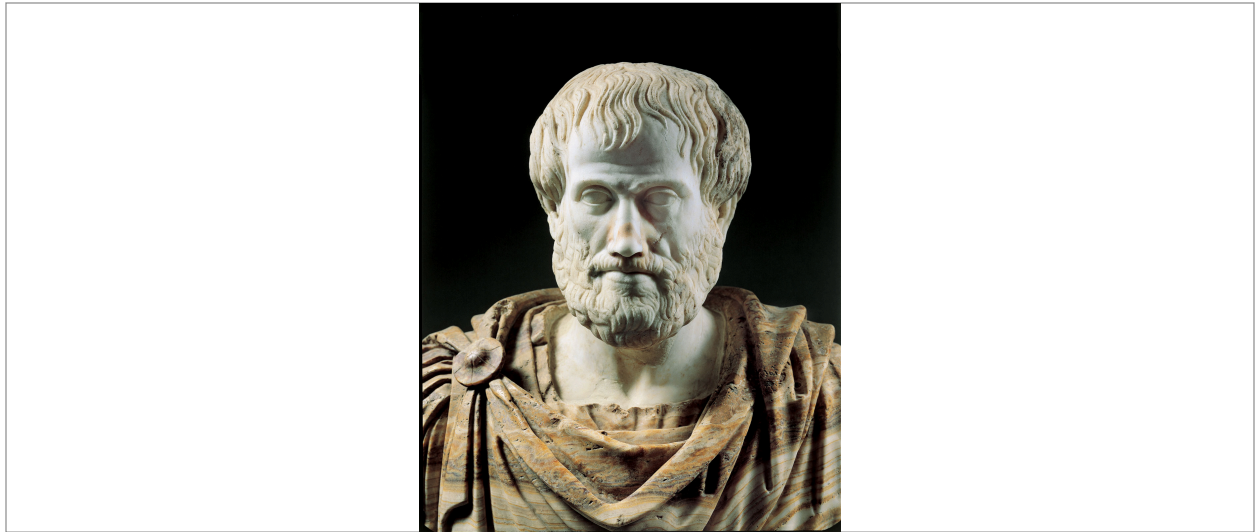
Virtue vs. Vice: Examples

Deficiency	Excess
Cowardice	Recklessness
Miserliness	Profligacy
Insensibility	Self-indulgence
Understatement	Boastfulness

This table illustrates Aristotle’s doctrine of the mean across several virtues. The virtuous disposition — courage, generosity, temperance, and truthfulness — lies between a deficiency on the left and an excess on the right. Note that the corresponding virtues (courage, generosity, temperance, truthfulness) are not shown here; students are asked to supply them.

Can virtue be taught?

This is one of the oldest questions in Greek ethics, raised in Plato's **Meno**. Aristotle's answer is nuanced: virtues cannot be taught the way mathematics is taught. They must be cultivated through habituation — by repeatedly performing virtuous actions until the disposition becomes stable and second nature.



Aristotle studied at Plato's Academy for twenty years before founding his own school, the Lyceum. His surviving works on ethics — primarily the **Nicomachean Ethics** and the **Eudemian Ethics** — remain foundational texts in moral philosophy.